

Target Tchepone

The once vibrant Laotian market town of Tchepone, about 27 miles (43 km) from the Vietnamese border, was a key transfer point along the trail and had attracted more bombing tonnage than any industrial city in Germany during World War II. All of the houses had been destroyed and the local people were living in caves, but the roads, communication network, antiaircraft artillery, and a rebuilt Buddhist temple continued to function. Truck convoys of 40 to 60 vehicles moved through the area each night on a maze of roads.

Marching into Laos

The ARVN advance along Route 9 toward Tchepone went easily for a few days. As trained by the US, South Vietnamese troops built fire support bases as they went. After an advance of about 12 miles (19 km) in two weeks, the ARVN column came under heavy attack. Contrary to earlier intelligence assessments indicating that the NVA in the area mainly consisted of logistics personnel with some security forces, the North Vietnamese quickly moved five divisions with field and antiaircraft artillery against the ARVN. Counting on US air support, the southern forces hunkered down in the firebases, but low clouds, antiaircraft fire, and the proximity of enemy to friendly forces negated the use of B-52s or low-level fighter bombers.

Despite heavy opposition, Thieu ordered the ARVN commander, General Hoang Xuan Lam, to launch an air assault on Tchepone itself. American UH-1 Hueys—with Cobra gunship protection—lifted two South Vietnamese battalions into the town. However, by March 1, Tchepone had been abandoned by the North Vietnamese, and the assault therefore had no military consequences. With the town successfully taken, President Thieu considered his objectives realized, and ordered Lam's forces to retreat.



Taking control

North Vietnamese troops attack a fire support base at Hill 31, Laos, 15 miles (24 km) northwest of an American border base at Lang Vei. Some 250 ARVN troops were killed, and Hill 31 fell to the NVA on the third day of heavy pressure. They soon set their sights on the nearby Hill 30.